In contrast, architectures establish stable points of control when they restrict AI to assisting and analyzing require authorization before retrieval, and log decisions consistently. They ensure that access decisions are observable, attributable, and reviewable.

This is how architecture supports accountability. It doesn't ensure sound decisions, but it clarifies responsibility and makes governance practical.

17.5.5 Policy as practice

Figure 17.5 clearly illustrates one last point: Policy is not a static artifact. It is a practice. Policies are written, evaluated, observed, questioned, revised, and managed over time. AI can support every stage of this process without replacing the systems that implement policy or the individuals responsible for its outcomes.

At ACME, this distinction proved crucial. AI enhanced the creation, analysis, and review of policies. Authorization limited what AI systems could access and perform. Governance procedures ensured that observed behavior stayed aligned with intent. Together, these elements transformed policy from a specification into an operational discipline. *This is how policy becomes practice.*

17.6 Summary

- Authorization needs predictability, transparency, and traceability, which AI systems cannot deliver.
- AI works best when it is limited to assistance roles such as drafting, explaining, and analyzing.
- Embedding authorization logic within prompts as text results in unpredictable and unsafe outcomes.
- Clear architectural boundaries stop AI systems from turning into implicit enforcement tools.
- Design-time intent and runtime behavior frequently differ, especially in complex policy systems.